Khrushchev first called out: ‘Long live the world revolution!’ Of course, he fanned the enthusiasm of the Berliners with that. He wanted to spur us on. Anyway, the international press was not so enamoured by the spontaneous – and even, perhaps, uncontrolled utterance, because he was a statesman.

9

The next morning, as the congress commenced, Walter Ulbricht strode out before 4,500 delegates to deliver a six-hour speech, crafted to please his Russian masters. He opened with a stinging attack on ‘dogmatists and sectarians’ in China, directed at Beijing’s chief delegate Wu Hseu Chwan, who ‘sat pokerfaced as the applause of the Khrushchev line mounted’. Such rhetoric was common since Khrushchev’s explosive secret speech. Differences in ideologies about communism had seen the once healthy Sino-Soviet alliance begin to crack, revealing serious conflicts beneath the veneer of solidarity. It ended with a breakdown in relations between the world’s two largest communist powers. From here on, China was often on the receiving end of spikey comments in GDR and Soviet propaganda and political speeches.

None of Ulbricht’s brusqueness was lost when he snapped at ‘narrowminded’ Albanian leaders, whom he described as ‘enemies of Marx and Lenin’ (the Albanians didn’t bother to attend the congress). However, the focus of the gathering, from a domestic point of view, was Ulbricht’s preview of economic reforms. Though Honecker largely remained in the shadows, he emerged to deliver a speech on leadership issues in which he snapped at lower party functionaries for acting ‘like little kings’. His voice low and precise, he regaled the story of Heinz Chill, the first party secretary of the Stralsund district, who told a veterinarian it was ‘up to her’ to have chicks hatched in June and laying eggs by New Year. ‘Even with the best ideological training, that is impossible for the chicks,’ he joked. On the